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Culture (OWC): [Gusii \(FL08\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1949

Coverage Date: 1946-1949

Place Coverage

Kavirondo Gulf region of Lake Victoria, western Kenya, East Africa

Section Title(S)

A clan census according to selective bases • Real and courtesy generations

Sometimes a demonstrable kinship dyad became superimposed (by marriage) on an incompatible non-demonstrable categorization 'in the clan'. Justino used to call Gisairo *sokoro* (grandfather) 'in the clan', until he married a second wife who was demonstrably related to a wife of Gisairo's. 'To this wife of Gisairo's my new wife is a "child", so I am now her "child" also, instead of "grandchild" as before. Her daughters have now learnt to call me "brother/cousin" instead of "child" as formerly.' Occasionally there was a situational choice between inconsistent categories, one non-demonstrable 'in the clan' and the other demonstrable through a subsequent marriage. 'I always used to call Anyiega my *tatamoke omoamate* (small father in the clan). But now that his second son has married a daughter of the half-brother of my second wife Nyanchama, I am entitled to call Anyiega *korera* (parent of spouse of child). And now when Anyiega wants to joke bawdily in my presence he calls me *korera*, though at other times, as my *tatamoke*, he behaves to me with restraint and will not enter my house.'

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When Justino could categorize the homestead head by a kinship term, obviously he could categorize everyone in the homestead too. To find out how many souls in his own clan he 'knew how to call' by kinship terms, then, we might multiply 140 by six, seven or more. This takes no account of the persons outside his clan whom he also 'knew how to call'—connections through mother, wives, grandmother, etc. Taking all of them together it seems reasonable to say that there must have been at least 1,500 persons whom he would place in nominal kinship categories, but probably not more than 250 for whom the categorizations would be 'real' and accountable for by genealogical demonstration; and that less than half of these were demonstrable agnates.

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Real and courtesy generations

It has been mentioned (p. 14) that the categorizations are often inconsistent with relative age, which might contribute to the impression that genuinely genealogical reckoning is being undertaken. The real explanation seems to be as follows. Gusii generation categories can cover very wide age ranges even among close demonstrable kin, starting with those in a compound family. Men do not merely aim at polygyny, they aim at taking a young wife when (and because) the old wife is past childbearing age. This preference will often result in the birth of 'real brothers' many years apart. Levirate and concubinage can increase the range further still. The youngest son of the youngest widow of a polygynist can be 30 or even 40 years younger than the eldest son by the first wife. They are the same genealogical generation while one is a generation senior by age. Any categorization which uses one of these men as an intermediate reference point—whether for true genealogical demonstration of kinship or for establishing courtesy categories merely—must necessarily be affected by this anomaly in relation to the other.

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